

Indian track stars chase the American dream

An increasing number of track and field athletes from the country are participating in Division 1 of the NCAA, widely regarded as the **pinnacle** of college sports.

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Pradeep Senthil Kumar admits he got a bit of a shock when he started his first year at the University of Nebraska. Born and raised in Chennai, the 21-year-old was barely prepared for the biting winter cold in the American Midwest.

"It rarely goes below 70°F here (approximately 20°C). It was really cold. When I came for the first time last winter, it was something like 21°F (-6°C), and it only got colder. I genuinely didn't know how to handle that. I was sick for a whole month," he says.

Switching between Fahrenheit and Celsius isn't the only Americanism Pradeep's getting used to. "It's actually very funny to me that I've started thinking of temperature in Fahrenheit. I've also started thinking in terms of pounds and yards instead of kilos and metres. It was really hard at the beginning. I just had my phone with me always to convert it," he tells *Sportstar*.

Pradeep's a lot more adept at these conversions and a lot more at home in Nebraska now. He's part of the University track team that competes in Division 1 of the NCAA (National College Athletics Association) — the highest level of collegiate sports in the USA.

In his first season (referred to as a junior year in the USA), Pradeep broke the Indian indoor national record twice — in the men's 600m and 800m, clocking times of 1:17.71 and 1:48.60, respectively.

He is incidentally not the only Indian to improve on the Indian national record this NCAA collegiate season. Competing for Wagner College, Arjanvir Singh clocked 22.26 seconds to improve on the Indian indoor record in the 200m. That result too came with its own unforeseen

challenge. "When I checked with the Indian federation, I realised that for it to count as a national record, I needed to get a dope test conducted after the competition. I hadn't really thought about something like this before. It's something I'll keep in mind before the start of the next indoor season," he tells *Sportstar*. He should get that opportunity soon enough.

There have been a bunch of impressive results by other Indian athletes in the collegiate circuit. Madhvendra Shekhawat equalled the Indian indoor record in the 60m hurdles. Long jumper Lokesh Sathyanathan qualified for the NCAA Indoor Championships — the pinnacle of the indoor track season in the collegiate circuit. While Lokesh was the only Indian to compete at that stage, he's not expected to be the last. That's a good thing.

Gold standard

For years, the NCAA has remained the gold standard as far as college sports structures go. At last year's Paris Olympics, it produced more gold medallists (127) than the USA and China combined. The champions belong not just to the US — from French hero Leon Marchand to Julien